

Final Essay: Spiritual Accountability

Throughout this class, we've learned a lot about how much Gonzaga University is connected with Native American people and, more specifically, those of the Columbia Plateau. For a long time now, the university has liked to celebrate its founders without revealing too much truth regarding the damage those founders caused to the local tribes. As students, we walk around a campus that was built on the homelands of the Spokane tribe without even giving it a second thought. We enjoy the views of the Spokane river, we built communities, and even profit off of the history, but we don't always think about what our presence here means for the people that have lived here for thousands of years. This semester has honestly changed my entire perspective on how I see Native Americans and their relationship with Gonzaga. I believe Gonzaga and our entire community need to take major steps to address this history, not only behind closed doors where we decide what is to be protected, but as a community and face our issues. To support my argument for how the University should act, I will draw on the perspectives of George Tinker, Neal Salisbury, and Vine Deloria Jr. to make my points and voice my opinions on transparency.

The first issue that we need to address is the way Gonzaga decides to represent their history to the public and students. Blurring the lines and omitting information for the sake of pride is not the way to do things. Most of the time, the story of Gonzaga begins in the late nineteenth century with the arrival of the Jesuit missionaries who came to bring education and religion to the frontier, but this narrative ignores the thousands of years of history that existed before any European even knew about the Columbia Plateau. In the article we read by Neal Salisbury, he explains that many people "continue to represent American history as having been set in motion by the arrival of European explorers and colonizers" (Salisbury, 436). This is exactly what Gonzaga does when it decides to omit the history of the land on which it has built its school. Salisbury argues that we have to look past this idea and see that there was a very complex and massive society here for thousands of years before Europeans showed up. He writes that we need to see the time before contact as "a single moment in a long history utterly detached from that of

Europe" (Salisbury, 436). When the Jesuits got here, they were not entering here; they weren't just entering an empty space, the Spokane people had a rich and complex history filled with politics, "religion", and even trade networks that were in a "state of profound flux" (Salisbury, 449). We need to make the real history of the Spokane tribe a core part of the story we tell everyone. That means everything from adding statues or memorabilia around campus, talking about this further in campus tours, and even on the school website, to honor the true history instead of omitting it to save face.

The issue of history not only pertains to the past, but it also affects our current Native American students, Native Americans who still live in Spokane, and even how we treat the actual land of our campus today. We are lucky to have the Spokane River next to the school, but the university treats it like real estate or a resource used for power and energy. We've built homes and buildings right up to the edge and even profit from the river and the history, but we barely treat it with the respect it deserves. George Tinker points out that "the Western world, long rooted in the evidential objectivity of science, distinguishes at least popularly between things that are alive and things that are inert" (Tinker, 106). Because of this Western mindset, many of us just see the river as water and the rocks as dead objects. But as we've learned in this course, the Spokane people see it far more than that. The river and even rocks aren't just objects meant for us to use as we wish, as Tinker explains, "American Indian peoples understand that all life forms not only have consciousness, but also have qualities that are either poorly developed or entirely lacking in humans" (Tinker, 106). This means the river and the land have their own rights and their own spirits.

To understand why this is a religious issue and not just an environmental one, I looked at this book called "God is Red" by Vine Deloria Junior. He was a very important Native American scholar who explained that Indigenous religions are tied to specific physical planes instead of just historical events. Deloria makes this very clear when he states that "American Indians hold their lands as having the highest possible meaning, and all their statements are made with this reference point in mind" (Deloria, 62). This means that for the Spokane people, the land Gonzaga is built on isn't just property; it's sacred land that is the center of their spiritual world. To me, that means every time the university builds a new structure without even asking the tribe

for input, it is a form of disrespect in several aspects. To fix this, I think the university needs to make some serious changes to our physical campus. We have plenty of statues of priests all over the place, but we need monuments and art that is created by the Spokane tribe. I also realize there is some Native American art in some parts of campus, but those are usually indoors and have to be found, and often students don't know what they represent. We should have these monuments and art in the middle of campus, notably by the quad or near the river, so that every student gets a real piece of history and thinks about it. We have to stop seeing the land as something we own and understand that it is a living place, and we are simply guests on it at this time.

Let's shift gears into discussing the difficult history of the missionaries who even started our school. George Tinker is very honest in his writing, explaining that even when missionaries thought they were doing a good thing, they were actually part of a system that tried to erase Native culture. Tinker writes that "the missionaries were partners in the genocide of Indian peoples, even though they were acting with the best of conscious intentions" (Tinker, 12). I realize this is a difficult reality for a catholic university, but being transparent is truly the best way to purify and move forward. The early missions were designed to eradicate the Native culture and religion to replace it with the Europeans way of life. This legacy is still with us today in the way we teach and the way we run the school. Tinker argues that Western culture has a habit of "elevating human beings to the apex of an evolutionary ascendancy" (Tinker, 108). To address this, Gonzaga needs to change its academic curriculum by requiring students to take a class like this one before they can graduate, no matter what their primary studies are. Personally, if I hadn't taken this class by some luck, I wouldn't have known about things I do know, and this information has been incredibly valuable to me and I think it would be for students across the world to know the history of the land they live on. No institutions should claim to offer a good education if they stay ignorant about their own foundations.

This brings me to my next point: the university must change how we teach in our classrooms. We should actively recruit more Native American professors and invite local elders to teach and talk to our students. We need to stop acting like we are the ones who always have the answers and start listening to the traditions that were here first. Tinker says that our job should be to "learn from other older beings and to pattern ourselves after their behavior" (Tinker, 108). This means

being humble and recognizing that we have a lot to learn from the Spokane natives and their relationship with this earth. This should also include changes to campus events by hosting meaningful partnerships with the tribe, where we listen and learn, along with events that even involve cleaning the river or learning about the local food and environment. This would be an excellent opportunity to practice reciprocity and would seriously benefit the people of the university, but instead, we force volunteering hours on our students that hardly offer any benefits.

Finally, the administration needs to be far more open to how decisions are made about land and campus projects instead of keeping them behind closed doors. Again and again, we must have transparency so the whole Zag community can see if we are actually respecting the local tribe. We need to move from just talking about social justice and actually start practicing it in our own school. Salisbury mentions that "Native Americans are integral to the history of colonial North America" (Salisbury, 435). If they are so integral to our history, then they should be a major part of our present-day decisions too. This is the only way to move toward spiritual accountability.

As a student, I want to feel like I am part of a community that is honest about its past. Now I know that the university has likely thought about these things in the past and is afraid of repercussions, but I don't think continuing to hide is the way to deal with the past. We cannot keep the history of the Spokane people as a small note in a book while we build a successful "non-profit" university on their home. By changing our classes, campus, and public image, we can start building a real relationship and move forward with integrity. It might take a lot of work, it might cost the school some money, and even make some people in administration uncomfortable, which I'm sure the school avoids, but in truth, it's the right thing to do. We owe it to the people of the Columbia Plateau to acknowledge their sacred landscapes and their spiritual resilience. Now it is up to Gonzaga to take those lessons and turn them into action in order to stop being part of the system that erases Indigenous voices and start being a partner to the future. This is how we truly honor the history and the present of the Columbia Plateau. We need to go beyond just talking about these ideas in a classroom and start living them everyday as part of what it means to be a student at Gonzaga University.

Works Cited

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